Iraq and its neighbours.

converting from coal to oil to fuel its ships, so oil was vital to Britain's defence needs.

When the First World War broke out in 1914, Turkey sided with Germany. Britain was keen to defeat Turkey and extend British influence, so British forces landed at Basra, in the south of Iraq (see the above map). This was the area where oil was later discovered. By 1917 the British had advanced to Baghdad and, a year later, they took Mosul. This meant that, in 1918, when the war ended, the British controlled the three provinces (Basra, Baghdad and Mosul) of what had been Turkish-ruled Iraq. The British commander announced: 'Our armies do not come into your cities and lands as conquerors or enemies, but as liberators.'

However, in 1916, Britain had agreed, with the French, to carve up Turkey's Arab lands when the war ended. This was in the Sykes–Picot Agreement (see page 8) under which Iraq was one of the countries assigned to Britain. At the end of the war the Treaty of Versailles recognised the British occupation of Iraq as a mandate according to which Iraq was to remain under British control 'until such time as it is able to stand alone'.

Key date
British granted mandate over Iraq: 1919

The British mandate in Iraq

This was a harsh blow to Iraqi nationalists, those who wanted (and, in some cases, had fought for) complete independence for Iraq. The British soon had a rebellion on their hands. They crushed it but they soon realised they could not run the country